I call my approach to nuclear weapons proliferation “strategic pessimism.” Unlike standard organizational pessimism, it challenges the core logic of proliferation optimism, showing that the danger of nuclear weapons will not necessarily lead rationally calculating states to behave in a cautious manner. Instead, under the right circumstances, nuclear danger can create incentives for states to adopt aggressive strategies, thereby destabilizing ongoing conflict relationships and creating a serious risk of catastrophic escalation.

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In chapter 4, we apply our theories to Indo-Pakistani militarized disputes from the late 1980s through 2002. The increased number of militarized disputes during the early phase of nuclearization and even the overt acquisition of nuclear weapons, Ganguly contends, were inextricably related to the exigencies of regional politics. Nuclear weapons, far from exacerbating these tensions, actually helped to constrain and limit these crises. None of these crises were allowed to spiral into full-scale war despite high level of tensions and the significant stakes involved in them. The contrast with the prenuclear era could not be more dramatic. In the prenuclear era, both states made very deliberate (if not always careful) plans for war (see chapter 2). However, as both states came increasingly close to crossing the nuclear Rubicon they evinced a growing recognition of the dangers of nuclear escalation.

Kapur, on the other hand, maintains that strategic pessimism is best able to account for instability in South Asia after India and Pakistan’s acquisition of nuclear weapons. As Pakistan developed a nuclear capability, its leaders decided that they could forcefully challenge territorial boundaries in Kashmir, the main source of Indo-Pakistani tension since partition. To this end they adopted policies ranging from the provision of extensive material support to the anti-Indian Kashmir insurgency, to the outright seizure of territory by the Pakistan Army. The Pakistanis believed that their nuclear capacity would prevent India from launching an all-out conventional attack in retaliation for these provocations. They also hoped that the danger of nuclear escalation in any ensuing crisis would attract international